

Unequal Structures and Agentic Selves

The Determinants of University Enrolment for Children of Migrants in Korea

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Abstract

South Korea has rapidly become a migrant-receiving society, yet the children of migrants reach adulthood with lower university enrolment than their peers. This dissertation asks what determines their entry into higher education, and how these determinants vary by degree type and gender. Bringing status attainment and segmented assimilation theory to the Korean case, it uses a complementary, non-nested mixed-methods design, comprising binary logistic models on 10 waves of the Multicultural Adolescents Panel Study (MAPS) alongside six in-depth semi-structured interviews. Household income has a robust effect on enrolment that persists after controlling for educational aspirations and achievement, contradicting earlier studies that find no income effect for this group. For academic degrees, parental education dominates and retains a direct effect. Social capital is largely absorbed into aspirations and achievement, while mother's country of origin shapes aspirations without directly affecting enrolment. Women's advantage operates chiefly through higher aspirations. The interviews show that income not only filters but sort students across institutions, that near-universal parental encouragement coexists with limited practical guidance often supplied by friends and teachers, and that legal status reconfigures access in the background. Structural constraint and individual agency jointly shape these trajectories.

Keywords: Children with migrant backgrounds, university enrolment, status attainment, mixed methods

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1. Introduction

Since the turn of the century, South Korea (hereinafter “Korea”) has seen a drastic increase in its immigrant population. Gradually, the children of early migrants are reaching adulthood, pursuing university education, and entering the workforce. But not everyone follows this conventional trajectory. Children with migrant backgrounds¹ (CMBs) are often in a place of compounded disadvantage, which hinders their educational and occupational prospects. Educational outcomes, or how far one makes it in the education system, matter as it largely determines the sort of job one has later in life (Blau and Duncan 1967). Universities in particular function as an important vehicle of social reproduction (Bourdieu 1977), not least in the context of increasing returns to college (Corak 2013). Therefore, dissecting the factors influencing CMBs’ entry into university has important implications for social mobility and inequality.

The ample literature on the integration of second-generation immigrants is Western-centric and neglects case studies from more recent migrant-receiving countries such as Korea. In contrast, studies from Korea are heavily policy-oriented and lack substantive theoretical backbones. This dissertation applies Western theories to the Korean case while remaining sensitive to the local context. Furthermore, the voices and agency of CMBs have traditionally been omitted from such studies. This study marginally addresses this issue through a mixed-method approach that complements quantitative analysis with primary interview data.

The overarching research question is: *What are the determinants of university enrolment of children with migrant backgrounds in Korea?* This question can be divided into a series of sub-

¹ “Children with Migrant Backgrounds” is the official term used in Korea to refer to children with at least one parent with a non-Korean origin.

questions under each methodological component. The quantitative section examines the following sub-questions: (1) *How do the determinants change by type (vocational, academic) of degree?* and (2) *How does this pattern differ by gender?* The qualitative section uses semi-structured interviews to (3) understand the processes underlying the statistical associations and (4) probe the subjective meaning assigned to higher education by the respondents.

This dissertation argues that the determinants of university enrolment differ considerably by degree type and gender. Household income has a significant effect on university enrolment even after accounting for mediating variables. Social capital has little meaningful effect. Mother's country of origin does not have any direct effects but has significant influence on CMBs' educational aspirations. Qualitative analysis adds nuance to the findings by showing how income shapes enrolment patterns more finely and that the dearth of practical support from parents can be compensated by friends and teachers.

The subsequent section reviews existing theoretical and empirical literature on the determinants of educational outcomes and provides additional context on the Korean migration and education system. The following section explains the methodological approach and describes how the data. The third section presents the analysis and discussion. The quantitative results are discussed first, then the qualitative results. The final section concludes by highlighting the implications for theory, policy, and limitations of the study. Further research is suggested.

2. Literature Review

2.1. Determinants of Educational Outcomes

2.1.1. Family Background

Status attainment theory by Blau and Duncan (1967) is the standard framework for explaining educational outcomes. Their original model emphasises the role of parental socioeconomic status (SES) on children's educational outcomes, measured in years of schooling. By now, it is well established that parental SES influences children's educational outcomes, migrants or not. However, why and how it does so is more contested. Part of this comes down to what aspect of SES is emphasised. Disciplinary differences come into play, with economists generally focusing on income and sociologists on occupation and education, or "class". Others examine the effect of each independently (Aldous 2006) or construct composite indices (Haller and Portes 2019). When studying migrants in particular, it can be useful to treat parental education separately from current income or occupation to account for the mismatch between pre- and post-migration status (e.g. Abada and Tenkorang 2009a; Portes and MacLeod 1999).

2.1.2. Individual Mediators

The Wisconsin model of status attainment extends the classical model by inserting social-psychological factors as mediators between SES and educational outcomes (Sewell et al. 1969). Social-psychological factors include the influence of significant others, notably parents, friends, and teachers, as well as the individual's educational aspirations and academic performance. Formally, the causal flows stem from SES to significant others to individual factors. Evidence abounds on the influence of SES on CMBs' academic aspiration (Kao and Tienda 1998; Salikutluk 2016) and achievement (Dustmann et al. 2012; Portes and MacLeod 1999). Unsurprisingly, both

are strong predictors of educational outcomes (Chesters 2015; Portes and Rumbaut 2001). Then the question becomes how much effect SES retains after accounting for these individual mediators (Haller and Portes 2019).

2.1.3. Social Capital

The role of significant others can be encapsulated in the concept of social capital, which refers to an individual's social network and the resources accessed through it (Bourdieu 2011). Social capital is notoriously diverse in definition and application (Portes 1998), resulting in divergent findings. Salikutluk (2016) identifies a strong influence of parents' and friends' educational wishes on immigrant youths' own aspirations. In contrast, Portes and MacLeod (1999) reports little to no significant effect of social capital on academic achievement once controlling for SES. While more systematic definitions have been proposed (Lin 1999) and found to have educational returns in certain contexts (Nygård and Behtoui 2020), collecting the required data can be impractical. Overall, these studies suggest two things. First, that it is the quality, not quantity, of one's relations that matters. Secondly, social capital, however operationalised, is not independent of SES (see also Li et al. 2008).

2.1.4. Segmented Assimilation

Segmented assimilation is a theory specific to CMBs. Originally proposed by Portes and Zhou (1993), it challenged the mainstream assimilation model by positing that second-generation migrants are integrated into different positions in society depending on their access to resources. While access to resources is principally determined by parental SES, segmented assimilation also highlights the importance of race and ethnicity, which shape the support received from co-ethnic communities (i.e. neighbourhood), the government (i.e. policy), and society in general (i.e. discrimination) (Portes and Rumbaut 2001; Telles and Ortiz 2008). Ethnic penalties and

advantages in immigrants' educational attainment have been observed across the West (Levels and Dronkers 2008). Again, the question is how much ethnic effect remains after controlling for SES and other factors (Haller and Portes 2019).

2.1.5. Gender

Finally, gender is important given highly gendered patterns of socialisation in all human societies (Portes and Rumbaut 2001). While most studies either control for gender or report its effect as significant, sometimes modelling men and women separately can be more insightful (Kao and Tienda 1998; Zuccotti and Platt 2023). Women have higher university enrolment rates than men in most high-income economies (OECD 2025), and such patterns are reflected among CMBs, with some ethnic differences (Abada and Tenkorang 2009b). It has also been suggested that women are more sensitive to parental education levels than men (Schneebaum et al. 2016). Considering these findings, gender disaggregated analysis will be conducted in addition to a pooled model.

2.2. The Korean Context

2.2.1. Migration and Multiculturalism

Understanding the Korean context is a prerequisite to accurately interpret the results of the analysis. Korea started receiving migrants in the 1990s, either through guestworker programmes (for men) or state-sponsored marriage migration (for women) (Chung 2020; De Haas et al. 2019)². As guestworkers could only reside for a limited number of years, marriage migrants became the first

² The number of migrants increased 10-fold between 1998 and 2025 (from 300,000 to 2.8 million) and now accounts for 5.4% of the total population (KOSTAT 2025b; Ministry of Justice 2026).

immigrants to permanently settle in Korea (H. M. Kim 2006)³. Most marriage migrants married into poor rural households and faced intersectional challenges of racial discrimination, unequal gender relations, and socio-economic precarity (Choi 2007; H. M. Kim 2006; Piper and Lee 2016; cf. M. Kim 2010).

As marriage migrants, their children, and their general vulnerabilities became more visible in the early 2000s, the government began implementing “multicultural” policies to provide targeted support and ostensibly challenge the popular perception of ethnic homogeneity, although scholars criticise these efforts as being assimilationist and exclusionary in essence (Moon 2006; Park 2010). These policies disproportionately prioritised multicultural⁴ children – considered to be the “2.5 generation” by some (e.g. Loi et al. 2026; Rumbaut 2004) – while neglecting other migrants (A. Kim 2016). As the migrant population continues to increase and diversify, so will the related social inequalities.

2.2.2. The Education System

The Korean education system comprises six years of primary school, three years of middle school, and three years of high school. Education is compulsory and free until middle school, but *tracking* – sorting students by academic ability – is introduced in high school. While the standardised national curriculum promotes greater equality in educational achievements (Werfhorst and Mijs 2010), the growing salience of private tutoring is challenging this effect (Bae and Choi 2024; W. Kim and Kim 2013).

³ The number of yearly marriages between Korean men and foreign women rose from 7,000 in 2000 to a peak of 31,000 in 2005, then stabilised at around 15,000 by the mid-2010s (KOSTAT 2026). Most of them come from China, Vietnam, Japan, and the Philippines (KOSTAT 2025a).

⁴ Officially, “multicultural” refer to households formed by marriage migrants and naturalised citizens in Korea.

Korea tops the OECD in university enrolment rate with more than 70% of the population aged 25-34 having completed tertiary education (OECD 2025). However, the sharp hierarchisation of higher education institutions undermines the progressive potential of enlarged accessibility (W. Kim and Kim 2013). Higher education institutions are distinguished between 4-year academic universities and 2/3-year vocational colleges. Although vocational college graduates have higher employment rates, a persistent and significant income gap remains relative to university graduates (Ministry of Education 2025a).

Overall, Korea's education system is a complex amalgamation of institutions that promote and hinder equitable outcomes. While the standardised institutions and curricula have progressive effects, this has been challenged by increasing neoliberalisation of the system (Byean 2015) and perforation by the shadow education industry (Ku et al. 2024). Their combined effect enhances the role of parental SES in determining the child's educational outcomes.

2.2.3. Determinants of University Enrolment

Using a nationally representative sample, W. Kim and Kim (2013) finds that parental SES affects the type of university attended even after controlling for parental support, educational aspirations, academic performance, and high school type. Looking more specifically at household income, Ku and Kim (2015) argue that income has both long and short-term effects on university enrolment. The cumulative effect of income is mediated by academic performance, which is explained by private spending and parental engagement in education. These patterns have been reflected in more recent studies (Hwang and Joo 2024).

Contrasting patterns are reported for CMBs. Lee and Cha (2019) found that parental social capital and education level had significant positive effects on entering university, while household income did not. Using the Multicultural Adolescents Panel Study (MAPS), Jang et al. (2024)

conclude that social-psychological factors are more important than socio-economic factors in determining entry into higher education. Another study using MAPS found that being male, living in or around the capital, and having a father with a university degree have significant positive effects on university enrolment, while household income does not (Yoon 2025).

These studies collectively suggest that the determinants of university enrolment for the majority group and CMBs are different. This aligns with official reports that CMBs have much lower enrolment rates and experience difficulties in socio-cultural adaptation. However, socio-cultural and socio-economic factors are confounded. The findings reported by previous studies are limited by data structure⁵, analytical strategy⁶, and some critical mistreatment of key explanatory variables⁷. Additionally, none of these studies includes mother's country of origin as an explanatory variable. This dissertation offers an alternative explanation through a theory-driven approach that fully exploits the longitudinal structure of the MAPS dataset, supplemented with primary interview data.

3. Methods and Data

3.1. Mixed Methods

3.1.1. Why Mixed Methods?

This study uses a mixed-methods research (MMR) design. MMR is useful for capturing different dimensions of a social phenomenon and providing a holistic understanding (Creswell and Creswell

⁵ Lee and Cha (2019) use cross-sectional data where income is measured in brackets. Yoon (2025) uses only wave 10 in his analysis, where income is reported in brackets.

⁶ Jang et al. (2024) use penalised regression and inputs data from every wave.

⁷ Lee and Cha (2019) log-transforms the categorical income variable. Yoon (2025) likely reverse-categorised gender.

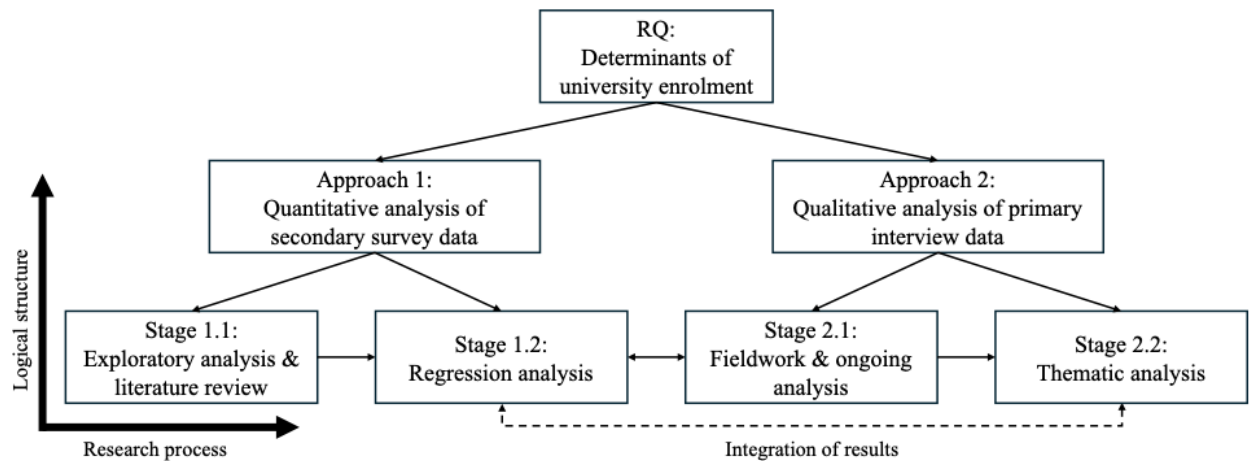
2023). Small-sample data can be used not merely to confirm findings from large-sample data but to delve deeper into the social process and provide alternative interpretations (Small 2011). Furthermore, interviews are powerful reminders of the human stories behind every statistic and can organically demonstrate how social processes play out in real life (Portes and Rumbaut 2001).

3.1.2. Design of the Study

Formally, this study uses a complementary non-nested sequential design (Small 2011). Complementary as the quantitative and qualitative analyses reinforce each other, and no methodology is considered superior. Non-nested means the interview sample is not a subset of the survey sample, which was inevitable because the quantitative analysis uses secondary data. Finally, it is sequential, as quantitative analysis was conducted first and shaped the questions asked in the interview. However, this sequence was not unilateral, and data collection (qualitative) and analysis (qualitative and quantitative) informed each other throughout the research process. Concretely, this involved testing themes emerging from interviews in the regression analysis (Doran et al. 2022).

The non-nested structure limits the possibility for extensive integration of findings from each approach. Instead of forcing a single harmonised conclusion, divergent findings will be candidly reported. Ultimately, integration is dynamic (Bazeley 2024) and achieved not only through one unified knowledge claim but fused into every stage of the research process. This study achieves integration by putting the two approaches in conversation throughout data collection, analysis, and presentation. **Figure 1** summarises the overall study design.

Figure 1. Visualisation of study design



3.2. Quantitative

3.2.1. Data

MAPS is a longitudinal survey conducted by the National Youth Policy Institute (NYPI) to track the development of multicultural children from childhood to early adulthood. The survey began in 2011 using two-stage sampling, first constructing the sampling frame by collecting the number of fourth-grade multicultural children in every primary school in the country, then using probability-proportional-to-size (PPS) to sample by region. The initial sample consists of 1,635 children.

The survey is ongoing, with the latest wave 15 being conducted in 2024. Data from waves 1 to 12 are used for this dissertation, but only those who participated in wave 10 are included in the analysis. The final sample includes 1,091 respondents, yielding an attrition rate of 33%. Attrition analysis using data from wave 1 suggests that income has a statistically significant but negligible effect on dropping out by wave 10 (**Appendix 1**). No official survey or attrition weights are provided due to lack of information on the target population.

3.2.2. Variables

Dependent Variable

The outcome of interest is whether CMBs entered higher education. Those who did are further distinguished between vocational and academic degrees. These outcomes are treated as two different thresholds (1: high school or less | university enrolment; 2: vocational degree or less | academic degree) and analysed as bivariate outcomes. The results for university enrolment are first reported in wave 10, a year after the last year of high school. As it is relatively common for Korean students to retake the high school graduation exam and apply for more prestigious universities, those who did not enrol in wave 10 but did in wave 12 were treated with their latest result, while the initial response was kept for those who dropped out between the waves. 63 university attendees were added through this adjustment, of which 48 pursued academic degrees.

Explanatory Variables

Explanatory variables are grouped into three categories – parental SES, individual mediators, social capital – with the addition of mother’s origin and gender. Parental SES consists of *equivalised household income* and *parental education*. Equivalised household income is calculated as the log of average combined income during high school divided by the square root of family size, accounting for the different financial needs by household size. Parental education is a dummy variable of whether at least one parent has a university degree.

For individual mediators, *educational aspiration* is measured as the desired level of education during the last year of middle school, which is when respondents were first asked about the precise level of education they want. For ease of comparison, educational aspiration is coded as desired years of schooling. *Educational achievement* takes the average of the respondent’s self-assessed academic performance in the five general subjects during the second year of high school. Second

year is preferred over third year as it is before practical decisions on university enrolment are made and has less risk of reverse causality (Ku and Kim 2015).

Social capital comprises the *support from parents, friends, and teachers* during high school, each calculated as an average of a set of questions. Finally, *mother's origin* is divided into four groups: Chinese (including ethnic Koreans, or *Joseonjok*), Japanese, Southeast Asian (comprising Vietnamese, Filipinas, and Thai), and Others (including the few Korean women with foreign husbands). Chinese serves as the reference group as they are the largest migrant group in Korea and culturally most akin. *Gender* is a dummy variable. See **Appendix 2** for a breakdown of how each variable was constructed.

Control Variables

Region of residence, area size, and family status are included as control variables. *Region* has five categories: Seoul, Gyeongin (Gyeonggi + Incheon), Chungcheong & Gangwon, Gyeongsang, and Jeolla & Jeju. Gyeongin is the reference category as it has the highest concentration of CMBs. *Area size* has three levels: city, town, and village. Family status is coded as a dummy variable for both parents being present or not, measured during the first year of high school.

3.2.3. Analytic Approach

As the dependent variables are dichotomous, binary logistic regressions are used. To enhance comparability between the effects of different types of variables, Gelman's (2008) recommendation of dividing by two standard deviations was adopted to make continuous variables directly comparable to binary variables. To facilitate coefficient interpretation and model comparison (Howell-Moroney 2024), average marginal effects (AMEs) are reported. See **Appendix 3** for the precise formulas.

For the main analysis, two binary logits were preferred over a single ordinal model because key explanatory variables were found to have non-linear effects over different educational thresholds, violating the proportional odds assumption. The same approach is applied to gender disaggregated analysis. Linear models (OLS) are used to explain the mediating roles of educational aspirations and academic performance. R was used for the analysis.

3.3. Qualitative

3.3.1. Recruitment Strategy

The inclusion criteria for the interview were adolescents living in Korea with at least one foreign-born parent aged 17 to 25, who completed all their high school education in Korea. The age range was set to include the present age of the MAPS cohort while being sufficiently flexible to capture recent high school graduates as well. Despite the seemingly relaxed criteria, it proved extremely difficult to find interviewees due to a small target population⁸ and general scepticism from gatekeepers and potential interviewees.

The first phase of recruitment was conducted online by reaching out to gatekeepers, mostly NGOs working with CMBs, some of whom I had personal relations with. I asked them if they could share the recruitment poster with my contact details and a link to an online sign-up form to people who met the inclusion criteria. This strategy proved ineffective as no interviewee was found. For the second phase, I was physically in Korea and asked everyone who had any marginal connection with the topic – teachers, professors, pastors, NGO workers, etc. – if they knew anyone who satisfied the criteria. Eventually, a few of them came back with volunteers, or had volunteers

⁸ According to the 2024 administrative census, the total number of CMBs aged 15 to 24 was 393,660. This includes temporary migrants such as international students who do not meet the inclusion criteria.

fill in the online form. Then I personally called the volunteers to check consent and arrange the interview. All the interviewees were directly recruited through a few key gatekeepers. Snowball sampling was considered but abandoned to maintain a diverse range of respondents. All interviews were conducted from June to July of 2026.

The final sample consists of six individuals, all but one of whom were not enrolled in or had graduated from university. The rest were enrolled in or had academic degrees. Four were women, and two were male. The age range was 18 (first-year university student) to 25 (university graduate). Crucially, only one CMB was a multicultural adolescent in the popular sense of the word – the child of a female marriage migrant and a Korean man. Another had a father who had naturalised. The rest did not have Korean citizenship, despite one being born in Korea. Another came to Korea when she was four. The remaining two migrated shortly before high school. Therefore, the sample is extremely selective, small, and heterogeneous, precluding any statistical generalisations. Given these limitations, the goal of the interviews is to construct cases to logically infer social processes (Small 2009), providing an in-depth understanding of the patterns identified in the quantitative analysis and suggesting alternative explanations where appropriate.

3.3.2. Interview Approach

Interviews were conducted in-person if possible. Two interviews were conducted at the university campus of the interviewee. One was conducted at the customer lounge of the interviewee's workplace. Another was conducted in a room in an NGO building near the residence of the interviewee. Two were conducted online due to practical reasons. Interviews lasted from 1 hour 20 minutes to 2 hours, with an average duration of 1 hour 40 minutes.

The interviews were semi-structured and revolved around the respondent's life history, with the interviewer (me) probing into the interviewee's relationship with significant others, educational

aspirations, and academic achievements throughout primary and secondary schooling. Speaking of past experiences is subject to many errors. A life history-informed approach was used to internally corroborate any reported motivations by developing a holistic profile of the interviewee's personality, asking about specific events, and identifying any inconsistencies (Small and Cook 2023). Additionally, since the long-term effects of SES cannot be directly questioned, it had to be proxied through questions on pocket money, part-time work, and shadow education. Nonetheless, a formal questionnaire on parental education and income was added at the end of the interview. The translated interview guide is presented in **Appendix 5**.

All interviews were conducted in Korean, recorded, and transcribed using ClovaNote if offline and by Microsoft Teams' built-in transcription system if online. The transcriptions were verified by me and coded abductively (Knott et al. 2022) using themes identified by previous literature, derived from the quantitative analysis, and emerging inductively from the interview itself. Coding was done using NVivo. All names mentioned in the discussion are pseudonyms. Some trivial details in quotes may be modified to protect the identity of the interviewees. Any significant edits and non-verbal details will be marked in [square brackets].

3.3.3. Ethics and Reflexivity

To ensure research ethics, all procedures and materials for interviewee recruitment was developed in continuous communication with the London School of Economics Research Ethics Review Board (RERB), the director of a Korean NGO working with CMBs, and a CMB with personal relations. Parental consent was obtained when interviewing a minor under the age of 18. Every interviewee was given a small compensation after the interview.

The small age gap with the interviewees was initially thought to promote accessibility and openness in interviews; I quickly discovered that this was not the case. In fact, proximity in age

accentuated the difference in social status between the interviewer and the interviewees. Doing a master's at a prestigious UK university was something most interviewees could not fathom. The context of migration, whether for the interviewees themselves or their parents, was strikingly different. This likely conditioned the interview dynamic and influenced what the interviewees chose to disclose and hold back. The interaction was unavoidably gendered as well.

4. Results and Discussion

4.1. Approach 1: Quantitative Analysis

4.1.1. Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics for each educational outcome are presented in **Table 1**. Of the 1,091 respondents, 26% were pursuing a vocational degree and 46% an academic degree, resulting in a total enrolment rate of 71%. As wave 10 was conducted in 2020, this figure is identical to the gross enrolment rate for that year (Ministry of Education 2025b). This finding diverges from the reported enrolment rate of 62% for CMBs in 2024, a 13%p lag relative to the total population (Ministry of Gender Equality and Family 2025). While this may be a feature of the MAPS cohort, it is also indicative of the educational catch-up by CMBs with the passage of time.

Those not pursuing a degree have lower equivalised household income (4.69) than the others but the gap between vocational (4.82) and bachelor's (4.83) degree is small, suggesting a non-linear effect. Those with parents without a university degree were relatively concentrated in vocational degrees and under (60%), while those with at least one parent with university education were most likely to be pursuing an academic degree (53%). Parental support increased by around 0.1 at each level. In contrast, friendship and teacher support were similar for those not in university and in vocational degrees, before jumping considerably (around 0.2) for academic degrees. Those

not in university had an average educational aspiration of 14.16 years. This transcends high school (12 years) by more than two years and shows that not everyone who wants to pursue further education is given the chance to do so. Those in academic degrees had an average of 15.62 years. Interestingly, those not in university had a higher average educational achievement (2.84) than those in vocational degrees (2.79). This is likely due to some high achievers continuing to retake the high school graduation exam even three years after graduation, which is not entirely uncommon in Korea. Those in academic degrees had a much higher average of 3.17. For mother's country of origin, children of Southeast Asian mothers were relatively likely not to be enrolled in university (33%), while those with Japanese mothers were most likely to be pursuing an academic degree (53%), 9%p higher than the runner-up, China (44%). Those with mothers not from these three countries/regions were the most likely to be in vocational degrees (31%) and the least likely to be in academic degrees (40%). As expected, very different patterns are observed by gender, with 33% of males not in university compared to only 24% of females, and 49% of females pursuing academic degrees compared to 43% of males.

Table 1. Educational outcome by explanatory and control variables

Variable	Below university	Vocational degree	Academic degree
<i>N (%)</i>	312 (29%)	278 (25%)	501 (46%)
Equivalised household income	4.69	4.82	4.83
Parental education			
Below university	31%	29%	40%
University	26%	22%	53%
Parental support	3.77	3.87	3.99
Friendship support	3.93	3.96	4.14
Teacher support	3.79	3.80	3.97
Educational aspiration	14.16	15.01	15.62
Educational achievement	2.84	2.79	3.17
Mother's origin			
China	27%	29%	44%
Japan	26%	21%	53%
Southeast Asia	33%	26%	41%
Other	29%	31%	40%
Gender			
Male	33%	24%	43%
Female	24%	27%	49%
Region			
Gyeongin	27%	31%	42%
Seoul	41%	24%	35%
Chungcheong & Gangwon	32%	21%	46%
Gyeongsang	23%	29%	48%
Jeolla & Jeju	26%	20%	54%
Area size			
Town	27%	28%	45%
City	30%	25%	45%
Village	29%	22%	49%
Family status			
Together	28%	25%	47%
Separated	28%	32%	40%

Note: Means for continuous variables and proportions for categorical variables. Reference group is mentioned first. Rows may not add up to 100% due to rounding.

4.1.2. Determinants of University Enrolment

Table 2 shows the effect of each variable on the likelihood of being enrolled in any type of university. Model 1 is the baseline “inequality of opportunity” model including only parental SES, mother’s country of origin, gender, and controls; variables that the respondent has no control over. Only income and gender have significant positive effects, each improving the chance of attending university by slightly over 10%. When social capital is added (model 2), the effect of income is reduced, but that of gender marginally increases. Only parental support is found to be significant. Model 3 adds education aspirations to the baseline model. Not surprisingly, educational aspiration has a large positive effect (17.8%). The effect of income only slightly diminishes while that of gender drops to 7.4%, suggesting that the female advantage is partially explained by higher educational aspirations. Model 4 replaces aspiration with achievement, which is found to have half the effect of aspiration. The effect of income is restored to around baseline level, while the gender effect reaches a new high, suggesting that female CMBs achieve better educational outcomes relative to their academic performance. Model 5 simultaneously captures all variables. Income continues to maintain a high effect (9.4%) while parental support loses significance. The effect of educational aspiration does not change much from model 3, but that of educational achievement decreases considerably from model 4.

Table 2. Determinant of university enrolment (binary logistic regression)

	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5
Equivalised household income	0.118*** (0.020)	0.107*** (0.021)	0.102*** (0.021)	0.112*** (0.020)	0.094*** (0.021)
Parental education (Ref: Below university)					
University	0.025 (0.029)	0.020 (0.029)	0.011 (0.028)	0.013 (0.029)	0.001 (0.028)
Parental support		0.069* (0.028)			0.043 (0.031)
Friendship support		0.033 (0.033)			0.014 (0.033)
Teacher support		0.010 (0.037)			0.001 (0.038)
Educational aspiration			0.178*** (0.015)		0.168*** (0.017)
Educational achievement				0.094*** (0.022)	0.056* (0.025)
Mother's origin (Ref: China)					
Japan	0.037 (0.037)	0.036 (0.037)	0.059 (0.036)	0.034 (0.037)	0.054 (0.037)
Southeast Asia	-0.049 (0.040)	-0.036 (0.040)	-0.017 (0.039)	-0.052 (0.039)	-0.016 (0.039)
Other	0.001 (0.059)	0.002 (0.060)	0.010 (0.057)	0.007 (0.060)	0.012 (0.056)
Gender (Ref: Male)					
Female	0.101*** (0.027)	0.106*** (0.027)	0.074** (0.026)	0.114*** (0.027)	0.087** (0.027)
<i>N</i>	1042	1042	1040	1025	1023

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Coefficient shows AME. Continuous variables are standardised by 2SD. Models control for region, area size, and family status. *N* can differ by model due to pairwise deletion. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

Income has a consistent (around 10%) significant effect in all models, suggesting that CMBs' university enrolment is highly sensitive to household income during high school. Income maintains its effect even after controlling for both educational aspiration and achievement. This contradicts findings from previous research suggesting that household income has no significant effect on

CMBs' university entrance (Lee and Cha 2019; Yoon 2025). Rather, it shows that financial constraints prevent students from pursuing further education even if they desire to do so, echoing findings from Ku and Kim (2015). This means that the factors determining the post-high school trajectory of CMBs are not radically different from those of Korean children. This is not surprising as almost all children of marriage migrants who were born in Korea are Korean, legally and culturally⁹. The rest of the variables will be discussed after examining the determinants of enrolment in an academic degree.

4.1.3. Determinants of Enrolment in an Academic Degree

Table 3 replicates the structure of **Table 2** for being enrolled in an academic degree. To avoid confusion, models are numbered using Roman numerals. Model I finds a significant but reduced effect of income and gender relative to model 1. Instead, parental education is found to be highly influential (12.1%). Mother's country of origin continues to have no significant effect. Adding social capital reduces the effect of income, although this time only friendship support is found to be significant. Model III shows that educational aspiration is highly associated with pursuing an academic degree (26.9%). Again, this is expected as those with higher aspirations naturally aim for higher degrees. Gender loses significance, proposing that the gender advantage for academic degrees is fully explained by higher aspirations among girls. Model IV shows that educational achievement is almost as influential as aspiration (24.2%) when treated independently. Like model 4, an improved gender effect compared to the baseline suggests that female CMBs outperform their grades. The significance of income disappears in model V, while the effect of parental

⁹ As Yujeong (25, academic degree) said, "I am 100% Korean and 10% Filipina".

education is reduced but remains significant. Educational aspiration and achievement continue to exert strong influence.

Table 3. Determinants of enrolment in an academic degree (binary logistic regression)

	MI	MII	MIII	MIV	MV
Equivalised household income	0.099** (0.032)	0.077* (0.032)	0.078* (0.031)	0.076* (0.031)	0.057 (0.031)
Parental education (Ref: Below university)					
University	0.121*** (0.033)	0.114*** (0.032)	0.107*** (0.031)	0.094** (0.032)	0.082** (0.031)
Parental support		0.045 (0.037)			0.005 (0.038)
Friendship support		0.088* (0.037)			0.027 (0.038)
Teacher support		0.051 (0.040)			0.026 (0.041)
Educational aspiration			0.269*** (0.029)		0.243*** (0.030)
Educational achievement				0.242*** (0.026)	0.202*** (0.029)
Mother's origin (Ref: China)					
Japan	0.050 (0.042)	0.045 (0.042)	0.078 (0.041)	0.045 (0.041)	0.067 (0.040)
Southeast Asia	-0.072 (0.064)	-0.079 (0.065)	-0.062 (0.060)	-0.077 (0.064)	-0.062 (0.060)
Other	-0.071 (0.043)	-0.064 (0.043)	-0.038 (0.042)	-0.072 (0.042)	-0.041 (0.041)
Gender (Ref: Male)					
Female	0.077* (0.030)	0.080** (0.030)	0.049 (0.029)	0.090** (0.029)	0.063* (0.029)
<i>N</i>	1042	1042	1040	1025	1023

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Coefficient shows AME. Continuous variables are standardised by 2SD. Models control for region, area size, and family status. *N* can differ by model due to pairwise deletion. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

Income continues to have a significant effect across models I-IV but is eclipsed by parental education. Income becoming non-significant in model V suggests that its effect on pursuing an academic degree operates indirectly by inspiring higher aspirations and grades. Parental education remains significant after controlling for aspiration and achievement, suggesting a direct effect. Why is this? As parental support is non-significant, parents with university degrees do not necessarily intervene more academically, assuming minimal measurement error. The explanation is unlikely to be institutional, as there is no legacy admission in Korea. Neither is it likely to be cultural capital, as the Korean education system punishes higher embodied cultural capital during high school (Byun et al. 2012). Further research is required to identify what this direct effect of parental education comprises (see also Holmlund et al. 2011).

4.1.4. Comparative Discussion

Comparing the two tables shows that the role of parental SES differs at each level of education. Income is more important than parental education for entrance into university generally, but the reverse is true when examining academic degree specifically. As observed in the descriptive analysis, this is partly the result of income's non-linear effect. This shows that despite household income and parental education being confounded, some independent effect is retained by each even after controlling for the other. The heterogeneous effect of different aspects of parental SES across multiple educational outcomes is not widely discussed in the literature and provides an interesting avenue for further investigation.

Social capital was seldom found to be significant. Nevertheless, parental support was associated with a higher probability of university enrolment (model 2), while support from friends mattered more for enrolment in an academic degree (model II). This is likely driven by parental support in the form of financial assistance (Ku and Kim 2015). Parents and friends are also

channels through which educational aspiration is transmitted (Salikutluk 2016). However, first-generation immigrant parents (mothers) are poor guides to the local education system (Portes and Rumbaut 2001), while Korean fathers tend to be less engaged with their children's education. Therefore, while the parents of CMBs may encourage their children to go to university, they have more difficulty providing practical advice on applying to universities (see section 4.2.3). Friends are an alternative source of information, especially as most school friends – which is what the variable captures (see **Appendix 2**) – are likely to be Korean and have better knowledge of the education system. Relationship with friends is also a strong proxy of how well the individual has settled into the school and the education system, increasing the likelihood of taking the conventional path of 4-year academic degrees. Nonetheless, the significance of both parental and friendship support disappearing in the full model suggests that any positive effect of social capital is fully translated into educational aspirations and achievement.

Educational aspiration and achievement have greater effects on enrolment in an academic degree compared to attending any university. This is straightforward, as those with higher aspirations apply to more advanced degrees, and academic degrees are more selective than vocational degrees. The much lower effect size of educational achievement in model 5 (5.6%) compared to model V (20.2%) shows how anyone who aspires to a vocational degree can attend it if they can afford it, which also explains why household income (9.4%) matters more than educational achievement (5.6%). As the two thresholds are not independent, the reported effects of aspiration and achievement can be considered upper bounds and will decrease or even disappear if those in academic degrees are excluded from **Table 2**.

Similar logic applies to **Table 3**, except that higher educational achievement by those not in university (2.84) than those in vocational degrees (2.79) suggests that the effect of educational

achievement will increase if non-university graduates are excluded. While the effect of educational achievement is non-linear when examined across these three basic levels, it becomes increasingly linear if more levels are added, accounting for institutional prestige (W. Kim and Kim 2013).

The unambiguous non-significance of mother's origin explains why there is not much previous research on this topic. This result is not entirely surprising considering Korea's context. First, MAPS almost exclusively focuses on the children of marriage migrants, a group with similar social backgrounds and common access to government support. Second, any potential ethnic effect is diluted through intermarriage. Thirdly, the nationalities represented in the sample are not as diverse as in traditional migrant receiving countries like the US. Fourthly, the reference group is not Korean families but those with Chinese mothers. Finally, the sample size may be too small to establish statistically significant relationships. Therefore, rather than concluding that race and ethnicity have no bearing on educational outcomes in Korea, it should be interpreted as reflecting both Korea's exclusivist migration regime and limitations in the data.

Being a woman has a significant positive effect in all models except model III. This directly contradicts findings from Yoon (2025) suggesting a male advantage in university enrolment. Both tables suggest that women have higher aspirations relative to their (1) male counterparts and (2) academic performance. This gendered difference in aspirations is widely observed across high-income economies (e.g. Brinbaum and Cebolla-Boado 2007; Holmberg et al. 2018; Kao and Tienda 1998) and is attributable to the different socialisation processes for men and women. The role of gender is discussed in more depth in section 0.

4.1.5. Determinants of Determinants

As expected, educational aspirations and achievement have the greatest influence on university enrolment across both thresholds. While the block entry models hint at the relationship between

different variables, a more formal analysis of the determinants of educational aspiration and achievement is warranted.

Table 4 is a linear regression examining the determinants of educational aspiration using the same specification as models 1 and I, the only difference being the use of household income during primary school to account for temporal precedence and explicitly including the control variables. Surprisingly, income does not have a significant effect. Having at least one parent with a university degree increases the desired years of schooling by 0.257 years. Unlike when examining educational outcomes, mother's origin does have a significant influence. Compared to CMBs with Chinese mothers, those with Japanese (-0.388) and Southeast Asian (-0.439) mothers have considerably lower educational aspirations. This matches previous findings of CMBs with Chinese mothers having the highest (Y. Kim et al. 2024) and those with Southeast Asian mothers having the lowest (Yun 2018) educational aspirations. This is explained by Chinese mothers' higher SES and better integration into Korean society, and the opposite scenario for Southeast Asian mothers. While this suggests some degree of segmented assimilation, to what extent it is reflected in university enrolment is difficult to assess. As discussed previously, gender has a positive effect (0.361). Additionally, living in Seoul (-0.787) and Jeolla province and Jeju Island (-0.595) have very high negative effects compared to those in the Gyeongin region. While Seoul is known to have the lowest university enrolment rate in the country due to intensified competition (Lim 2026), it is less clear why CMBs in Jeolla and Jeju have such low aspirations.

Table 4. Determinants of educational aspirations (OLS)

	B	
Constant	15.158***	(0.198)
Equivalised household income (primary school)	0.261	(0.140)
Parental education (Ref: Below university)		
University	0.257*	(0.128)
Mother's origin (Ref: China)		
Japan	-0.388*	(0.161)
Southeast Asia	-0.439**	(0.168)
Other	-0.149	(0.248)
Gender (Ref: Male)		
Female	0.361**	(0.118)
Region (Ref: Gyeongin)		
Seoul	-0.787**	(0.259)
Chungcheong & Gangwon	0.137	(0.188)
Gyeongsang	-0.211	(0.177)
Jeolla & Jeju	-0.595**	(0.212)
Area size (Ref: Town)		
City	0.280	(0.172)
Village	0.283	(0.166)
Family status (Ref: Together)		
Separated	-0.384	(0.235)
<i>N</i>	1040	
<i>R</i> ²	0.051	

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Income is standardised by 2SD. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

Table 5 replicates the same analysis using educational achievements as the outcome. The pattern differs considerably. Only income (0.093), parental education (0.156), and living in a city (0.157) have significant effects. Although small, the significance of income during primary school shows the long-term cumulative effects of income on academic achievement by determining access to extracurricular resources (Entwisle 1997), which spills over to educational outcomes (Ku and Kim 2015). Educated parents are another important extracurricular resource available to CMBs and may compensate for relative lack of financial investment in education for resource-constrained

households (Urban 2012). Genetic selection can also play a part (Holmlund et al. 2011). Finally, living in a city allows superior access to private and public educational support institutions, especially those targeting CMBs. This may explain the better academic performance of CMBs living in cities relative to those in towns or villages.

Table 5. Determinants of educational achievements (OLS)

	B	
Constant	2.900***	(0.071)
Equivalised household income (primary school)	0.093*	(0.047)
Parental education (Ref: Below university)		
University	0.156***	(0.045)
Mother's origin (Ref: China)		
Japan	-0.017	(0.061)
Southeast Asia	-0.024	(0.059)
Other	-0.033	(0.101)
Gender (Ref: Male)		
Female	-0.040	(0.043)
Region (Ref: Gyeongin)		
Seoul	-0.137	(0.101)
Chungcheong & Gangwon	0.016	(0.066)
Gyeongsang	0.016	(0.063)
Jeolla & Jeju	-0.012	(0.069)
Area size (Ref: Town)		
City	0.157**	(0.059)
Village	0.081	(0.054)
Family status (Ref: Together)		
Separated	-0.031	(0.083)
<i>N</i>	1025	
<i>R</i> ²	0.026	

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Income is standardised by 2SD. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

4.1.6. Gender Differentials

Finally, **Table 6** fits separate models for men and women at each level of outcome. The results show significant differences in the modes of university enrolment by gender. Household income has a significant effect at both levels for men, and not at all for women. While parental education is insignificant when examining university enrolment alone, it has a significant effect (10.3%) on the likelihood of female CMBs enrolling in an academic degree. Parental support positively influences university enrolment for men (11.4%) but has no statistically meaningful effect for women. Aspiration has a sizeable significant effect across all level-gender combinations. For men, educational achievement has no significant influence on university enrolment. For women, educational aspiration (14.6%) is more important than achievement (7.7%) for enrolment into university, but the influence of achievement becomes slightly greater for academic degrees.

These results add nuance to the heterogeneous effect of parental SES identified earlier, showing that income matters for men and parental education for women, but only for pursuing an academic degree. Relative sensitivity to income reflects how men, especially from lower SES households, see university education as optional, provided easier access to the secondary labour market (Oh and Kim 2019). Women lack such access and default to pursuing university education at any level, regardless of household income. For women, parental education has a stronger social reproduction effect. This aligns with findings from Schneebaum et al. (2016) that women are more sensitive to parental education than men. The significant effect of parental support for men's university enrolment illustrates that parental engagement matters for men, while women do not require such encouragement to pursue further education. For both outcomes, educational aspiration has a greater effect on men than on women, and the opposite is true for educational achievement. This reflects women's higher aspirations and relative sensitivity to grades, especially when

pursuing an academic degree. In contrast, having higher aspirations matters more for men, who typically have lower aspirations than women.

Table 6. Determinants of enrolment at each level of outcome for men and women (binary logistic regression)

	<i>University enrolment</i>		<i>Academic degree</i>	
	Men	Women	Men	Women
Equivalised household income	0.153*** (0.029)	0.037 (0.032)	0.093* (0.042)	0.022 (0.044)
Parental education (Ref: Below university)				
University	0.004 (0.042)	0.003 (0.038)	0.052 (0.043)	0.103* (0.044)
Parental support	0.114** (0.041)	-0.004 (0.047)	0.092 (0.058)	-0.058 (0.053)
Friendship support	-0.024 (0.059)	0.021 (0.038)	0.017 (0.057)	0.026 (0.052)
Teacher support	-0.067 (0.069)	0.064 (0.036)	-0.011 (0.060)	0.059 (0.057)
Educational aspiration	0.192*** (0.024)	0.146*** (0.022)	0.276*** (0.039)	0.210*** (0.047)
Educational achievement	0.043 (0.036)	0.077* (0.033)	0.165*** (0.043)	0.235*** (0.040)
Mother's origin (Ref: China)				
Japan	0.032 (0.056)	0.077 (0.048)	0.040 (0.055)	0.106 (0.057)
Southeast Asia	0.051 (0.076)	-0.023 (0.080)	-0.053 (0.083)	-0.062 (0.081)
Other	-0.011 (0.058)	-0.017 (0.052)	-0.022 (0.059)	-0.055 (0.059)
<i>N</i>	498	525	498	525

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Coefficient shows AME. Continuous variables are standardised by 2SD for the combined sample. Models control for region, area size, and family status. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

4.2. Approach 2: Qualitative Analysis

The qualitative analysis helps make sense of some of the patterns identified in the previous section, especially the role of parental SES and social capital. The implications of one factor that did not feature in the quantitative analysis, legal status, are also highlighted. Discussion on gender and mother's origin are excluded due to limitations in the sample.

4.2.1. Going to University is the Norm

The interviews collectively highlighted that going to university is the norm under any circumstance. Even though most students did not have concrete aspirations nor performed well during middle and high school, they found it natural to attend university. As Jisoo, who completed an academic degree and is currently pursuing a master's, put it:

Most Chinese students think that they must go to university. Both parents and the student themselves think this, so going to university is a must.

In fact, it proved difficult to avoid university even if one wanted to. Sumin, who moved to Korea when she was four, had no interest in studying and did not plan to go to university. However, her homeroom teacher in the last year of high school called her mother to “let Sumin go to university” and helped with her applications. Sumin is currently a first-year student doing an academic degree in the humanities. When probed why she did not want to go to university, she responded:

I just wanted to do pet grooming and go directly into work, but my teacher said that “nowadays we should at least go to university”. I said I would think about it and didn't work on my application, but my teacher said to think again, and I thought this would just keep on going so I just did it.

Although not aspiring to go to university is uncommon, it is equally difficult to find cases where the student had a clear idea of what they wanted to do after high school. This is normal as most people go to university without a clear sense of purpose, but treat university as the obvious next step in the journey of self-discovery (Jang et al. 2024). Attending this university and studying that major always makes more sense in retrospect than in the moment of unfolding. The actual outcome is a combination of the opportunity structure and the agency of the individual shaped through their life trajectory (Holmberg et al. 2018). As Yujeong candidly expresses:

During high school, I did not have much thought. Really, I just chose to study social welfare because I couldn't think of anything better to do. But I know people don't study social welfare just because they have nothing to do, so at university I spent some time for introspection [...] and thought that my [activities during high school] and early experience with social welfare workers probably had an influence.

4.2.2. The Absolute Role of Money

The importance of family finances was latently visible throughout the interviews. Those attending relatively prestigious private universities had the highest household income. Those attending national universities reported lower income or refused to give a figure. Hyuk, the only interviewee who did not go to university, had little choice as unfortunate circumstances forced him to work from high school to support his family. Therefore, as discussed in the previous section, household income has a direct impact on the student's choice of attending university.

Beyond the minimal threshold, income has a more subtle effect. Rather than determining whether one can or cannot go to university, it shapes the type of university one can apply to, a finer distinction not captured in the statistics. As the main costs related to universities are tuition and

housing, CMBs from lower-income households face difficulty applying to universities that have high tuition or are further away from home. Yujeong explains her application decisions:

I applied to two universities [...] because they were national universities and nearer to home. I could not apply to universities in Seoul or private universities as I thought they would be too financially burdensome.

Tuitions for national universities are around half that of private universities. National universities are also better connected to means-tested financial aid, significantly lessening pressure for students. While national universities are not strictly worse than private universities, the increasing stratification of universities is inflating the merit of private institutions, especially those located in Seoul. This means that where one lives matters by increasing or decreasing the cost of attending certain universities. Therefore, household income has not just a filtering effect, blocking some from entering university entirely, but also has a sorting effect, placing students in institutions permitted by their financial situation. This agrees with what W. Kim and Kim (2013) found looking at the cumulative effect of SES.

4.2.3. The Paradoxical Role of Parental Education

Both parents with higher education degrees and those without seemed to encourage university enrolment for their children. For CMBs with parents who had university degrees, going to university was the obvious choice. Alifah, who came to Korea during middle school and is enrolled in an academic degree, said:

My family thinks that education is important, so I thought of going to university from the beginning [...] My maternal grandparents both studied until a master's degree.

In contrast, parents, especially mothers, who do not have a university degree may aspire for their children's education as compensation for their own lack of schooling. Yujeong's case exemplifies this. When asked if her parents would not have cared whether she went to university or not, she replied:

No, I did have to go. My mother had an unfulfilled desire for education. She was born as the second child among nine, so she had to work instead of going to school [...] So graduating from school became a dream for her children, since she couldn't do it herself. It didn't matter which university, but I had to go.

The above quote further highlights the limits of parental aspirations: it pushes towards a general outcome but not at a specific level. Therefore, while most parents encourage their children to pursue higher education regardless of their own education level, only a few can offer practical support. This is the consequence of both financial constraints preventing investment in extracurricular classes and a genuine lack of knowledge of the system. Indeed, among those interviewed, there was only one case of the parent being actively involved in education. On one extreme there are Tommy's parents:

My parents thought I was a model student, because if you have a foreign name, you are usually given small classroom numbers, and my parents always believed this to be my class rank.

Tommy's parents never intervened academically until recently, when they received Tommy's grades from university. However, until high school, they gave him the freedom to choose his own path, even if that meant not going to university. On the other end, Sumin's mother, who had a 4-year university degree, pressured her daughter academically throughout middle school before

giving up in high school when it became obvious that Sumin had no interest in studying. Sumin's case shows how educational transmission is not always straightforward, and that excessive parental intervention can backfire by brewing resistance (Jang et al. 2024; Noh and Shin 2024). From Sumin's perspective:

Since I didn't study, my mom would keep telling me to study, but when you get told to study, you want to do it less and don't do it, so my grades would keep dropping, and my mom would scold me [...].

4.2.4. Significant Others Outside the Family

For students, friends and teachers are the main social resources beyond the family. Friends play a crucial role in shaping the educational aspirations of CMBs (Salikutluk 2016). This can take the form of encouraging or opposing educational achievement, shaped by the particular sub-culture CMBs are exposed to (Kao and Tienda 1998). Therefore, good relationships with friends can have both positive and negative implications on university enrolment, although the statistical analysis suggests that the association is generally positive. Tommy, who went to a vocational high school, initially wanted to go straight into work. However, testimonies of in-work difficulties and shifting aspirations from his friends inspired him to change his trajectory in the last year of high school. Once that decision was made, he could work on his university application with his friends:

I prepared with [Harry], who has been my friend from primary to high school, checking if any documents were missing. I got them checked with my teacher, too.

In contrast, interviewees whose envisioned trajectory diverged from their high school friends tended to differentiate themselves. Alifah, coming from a highly educated family, found herself in a vocational girls' high school. When asked to comment on her school, she said:

I had the feeling that... people in my school hadn't received proper education from their parents [laughing]. It could be because it was a vocational high school.

This boundary-making took place at the opposite end as well. When asked about his relationship with high school friends, Hyuk responded:

To be really honest, they were a bit too young. They always talked about unrealistic stuff [...] and this is normal, but it was just a difficult time for me, so... I woke up.

Teachers can offer practical support by recommending alternative pathways and assisting with university applications (Voyer and Lund 2026), something parents have difficulty with. This was best illustrated by Sumin's case, where her homeroom teacher convinced both Sumin and Sumin's mother to apply to university. Others like Tommy reported receiving similar help from teachers, especially in the final year of high school.

However, it seemed as if teachers were more eager to help CMBs with foreign nationality than with Korean citizenship. This could be because teachers perceive the former to be more in need of help. Although the interview sample is too small to provide a compelling explanation, the insignificant effect of teacher support in the quantitative analysis suggests that either very helpful teachers are rare or that the relationship with teachers in general does not matter as much as dedicated help from a single teacher in the last year of high school.

4.2.5. Backdrop of Legal Status

One mechanism irrelevant in the quantitative analysis arose during the interviews: legal status. Counterintuitively, those without Korean citizenship had better access to universities than those who did. This was because students with foreign nationality could take advantage of international admissions, which set a much lower bar on grades for foreign students while rewarding Korean

language skills. Most interviewees fit this profile perfectly, as long-term CMBs tend to have low educational achievement but advanced Korean skills. For CMBs with insecure visa status, access to student visas provides one of the only viable pathways for legitimate stay. For these students, enrolling in university is not so much the result of their aspirations or social status as a necessary choice to protect their daily lives.

Regardless of the motivation, the enhanced access to universities produces a mismatch between the CMBs' actual ability and that expected by their degrees, resulting in severe academic underperformance. For more recent migrants like Alifah, accessibility to university provides the opportunity to address the mismatch between her pre- and post-migration status. Legal status therefore intersects with SES, individual mediators, and other factors discussed throughout the dissertation to complicate the meaning of university. How these different dimensions impact the occupational prospects of CMBs is a question for the future.

4.2.6. The Heterogeneous Meaning of University

Hitherto, the different levels of educational outcomes were considered to have rigid social connotations. But university education does not carry the same meaning for everyone. For CMBs who have been socialised in Korea, universities were clearly hierarchised and offered different value depending on institutional prestige. As Sumin summarised:

Honestly, if you are going [to university], it is better to go somewhere even people in the boondocks would know [...] If you are going.

For CMBs who regarded university as the remedy to a blocked opportunity, being in university mattered more than the type and prestige of the institution. When asked if she had any apprehensions regarding the future, Alifah, after a brief pause, replied:

I am happy right now. I don't have many worries.

Finally, for Hyuk, universities are optional. Based on his own life history, he came to see experience as being more important than formal education for being successful in life. Throughout the interview, he emphasised his duty to his family and the lessons learned from financial hardships to construct an agentic self in resistance to unequal structural realities (Ho 2024):

This is how I see it. Go to university if needed, but if not then don't. Of course, going to university has more benefits, but I think a bit differently because you can invest in real experience during the same time [...] Because this [pointing at head] and doing this [twirling fingers] are completely different. Completely different.

Hyuk's case is particularly interesting as it shows that not everyone who does not go to university is on a downward trajectory. Hyuk was more confident about his current and future life than any interviewee who went to university. This complicates reducing educational outcomes to a unilateral sorting mechanism. However, the long-term socioeconomic outcomes are less clear for highly motivated high school graduates, and as Hyuk was also positively selected for the interview, it is a stretch to extend his case to other CMBs who did not enrol in university.

5. Conclusion

This dissertation asked what determines university enrolment among CMBs in Korea, and how these determinants differ by degree type and gender. Drawing on the MAPS dataset and six semi-structured interviews, it advanced three main arguments. First, the determinants of enrolment are neither uniform nor reducible to a single dimension of parental SES. Household income drives entry into university in general and retains a significant effect after controlling for educational aspirations and achievement, whereas parental education matters specifically for academic degrees.

Second, educational aspirations and achievements perform much of the mediating work as predicted by the Wisconsin model. Third, mothers' country of origin has no direct effect on enrolment but structures aspirations. Women's advantage is largely explained by superior aspirations. The interviews located the mechanisms behind these patterns. Money both filters and sorts. Parents encourage university enrolment but rarely offer practical guidance, which is frequently outsourced to friends and teachers. Legal status silently shapes access to university through international admissions. Unequal structures and agentic selves co-produce these trajectories.

The findings speak to three bodies of theory. For status attainment, disaggregating parental SES reveals that its components operate through different channels and at different educational thresholds, a heterogeneity that the classical approach obscures. For the Wisconsin model, the near-complete mediation of social capital and the partial mediation of income confirm that aspirations and achievement are the proximate engines of attainment. However, income's persistent effect on enrolment shows that socio-psychological mediation cannot fully absorb material constraint. For segmented assimilation, the absence of any direct ethnic effect on university enrolment amid a significant effect on aspirations suggests the theory travels only partially to Korea. However, such patterns are due to change with the continued diversification of migrants in Korea. Finally, the qualitative material injects agency and meaning into the status attainment process.

These findings have concrete policy implications. The critical role of household income during high school advocates for enhanced access to scholarships and loans for credit-constrained students. Access means not simple availability, but active communication of existing opportunities to those who are excluded from learning about them, especially CMBs living in smaller towns and villages. This intervention is better made earlier than later, as Yujeong points out:

Like when we start not to do something, and it becomes a habit, I never had access to information, so even when new information came to me, I didn't know how important it could be to me.

The different patterns by gender suggest that academic assistance can be more effective for girls, while positive role models and shaping aspirations from an early age can be effective for boys. Beyond SES, the findings caution against treating CMBs as a homogeneous category or university degrees as a single good. Because parental encouragement rarely translates into practical guidance, schools and teachers should be resourced to provide the application support that migrant parents often cannot. Beyond formal education, children's centres can also be sites of positive socialisation, while directly informing parents about Korea's education system and the opportunities available to their child can do much work.

Several limitations qualify these conclusions. On the quantitative side, MAPS overwhelmingly samples the children of marriage migrants, so the results speak to this population rather than to CMBs as a whole. The exclusion of many recent migrants is precisely the gap the interviews began to fill. Attrition of a third of the original cohort, the absence of survey weights, and reliance on self-reported achievement introduce further uncertainty. The unexplained direct effect of parental education is an omitted-variable problem that the present design cannot resolve. On the qualitative side, six highly selective and heterogeneous cases permit conceptual, not statistical, generalisation. Recruitment difficulties, retrospective accounts, and the interviewer's positionality all shaped what could be learned. Finally, the non-nested design constrains how tightly the two strands can be integrated, and divergences have been reported as such rather than forced into agreement.

Future work could pursue several directions. The direct effect of parental education invites further investigation to identify what, beyond income and knowledge support, educated parents transmit. Regarding data, larger, more diverse samples reaching beyond the children of marriage migrants to labour and undocumented migrants would allow ethnicity and legal status to be modelled directly rather than inferred. The new MAPS2 dataset is an honourable effort. Extending the analysis from enrolment to institutional prestige, and onward to labour-market outcomes, would test whether the income effect observed here compounds into occupational inequality. More dedicated attention to gendered patterns is also needed. Finally, comparative designs across Asia's newer migrant-receiving states would clarify how much of the Korean pattern is contextual.

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7. Appendix

Appendix 1. Attrition analysis (binary logistic regression)

	OR	
Equivalised household income	1.003***	(0.001)
Parental education (Ref: Below university)		
University	1.151	(0.137)
Mother's origin (Ref: China)		
Japan	0.602***	(0.091)
Southeast Asia	0.739*	(0.111)
Other	0.987	(0.202)
Gender (Ref: Male)		
Female	0.918	(0.101)
Region (Ref: Gyeongin)		
Seoul	1.074	(0.200)
Chungcheong & Gangwon	0.659*	(0.137)
Gyeongsang	0.744	(0.147)
Jeolla & Jeju	0.578**	(0.122)
Family status (Ref: Together)		
Separated	1.122	(0.406)
<i>N</i>	1583	

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Coefficients are the odds ratio of dropping out by wave 10. *N* is smaller than survey sample as NAs are dropped. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

Appendix 2. Detailed explanation of the dependent and explanatory variables

Variable	Type	Explanation	Waves
University enrolment	Categorical (binary)	- No: Reported as not enrolled in university in <i>both</i> waves 10 and 12, or reported as not enrolled in university in wave 10 and dropped out in wave 12 - Yes: Reported as enrolled in university in <i>either</i> waves 10 or 12	10, 12
Academic degree	Categorical (binary)	- No: Reported as not enrolled in academic degree in <i>both</i> waves 10 and 12, or reported as not enrolled in academic degree in wave 10 and dropped out in wave 12 - Yes: Reported as enrolled in academic degree in <i>either</i> waves 10 or 12	10, 12
Equivalised household income	Continuous	$\ln \left(\frac{\frac{1}{3} \sum_{w=7}^9 y_{iw}}{\sqrt{h_{i,w=7}}} \right)$ where y_i is household income and h_i is household size	7, 8, 9
Parental education	Categorical (binary)	- Reference: None of the parents have a university degree - Comparison: At least one parent has a university degree	1

Variable	Type	Explanation	Waves
Educational aspiration	Continuous	Numerical translation (years) of desired educational level in the last year middle school • Middle school = 9 • High school = 12 • Vocational degree = 14.5 • Academic degree = 16 • Master's degree = 18 • Doctoral degree = 23	6
Educational achievement	Continuous	$\frac{1}{k} \sum_{m=1}^k g_{im,w=8}$ where g is the response to the question*: • <i>Honestly select the number that corresponds to your grade for each subject</i> The subjects (m) are: 1. <i>Korean</i> 2. <i>English</i> 3. <i>Mathematics</i> 4. <i>Society (geography, history, ethics, economics, politics, etc.)</i> 5. <i>Science (physics, chemistry, biology, earth science, etc.)</i>	8
Parental support	Continuous	$\frac{1}{3} \sum_{w=7}^9 \left(\frac{1}{k} \sum_{m=1}^k sup_{imw}^{parent} \right)$ There are 9 questions* ($k = 9$) on parental support: 1. <i>My parents know and understand me well</i> 2. <i>My parents listen to my concerns</i> 3. <i>My parents comfort me when I am having a hard time</i> 4. <i>My parents give advice on school or career issues</i> 5. <i>My parents give helpful advice for studying</i> 6. <i>My parents provide good books and necessary information</i> 7. <i>My parents give me pocket money</i> 8. <i>My parents buy things needed for studying</i> 9. <i>My parents provide financial support</i>	7, 8, 9
Friendship support	Continuous	$\frac{1}{3} \sum_{w=7}^9 \left(\frac{1}{k} \sum_{m=1}^k sup_{imw}^{friends} \right)$ There are 4 questions* ($k = 4$) on friendship support: 1. <i>My school friends understand me well</i> 2. <i>My school friends comfort me when I am lonely</i> 3. <i>I hang out with my school friends after school</i> 4. <i>My school friends respect and care for me</i>	7, 8, 9
Teacher support	Continuous	$\frac{1}{3} \sum_{w=7}^9 \left(\frac{1}{k} \sum_{m=1}^k sup_{imw}^{teachers} \right)$ There are 3 questions* ($k = 3$) on teacher support: 1. <i>When I have a problem at school, there is a teacher I can discuss it with</i> 2. <i>Teachers at my school are kind to me</i> 3. <i>I like the teachers at my school</i>	7, 8, 9

Variable	Type	Explanation	Waves
Mother's origin	Categorical (multinomial)	Small groups are merged into larger categories - Chinese = Chinese (Han) + Chinese (Joseonjok) - Japanese = Japanese - Southeast Asian = Vietnamese + Filipinas + Thai - Others = Other + Korean	1

* Question response on a 5-point Likert scale

Note: Gender and control variables are excluded as they are used as given.

Appendix 3. Functional form of the binary logistic regression and reported coefficients

Binary logistic models take the form

$$\text{logit}(\pi_i) = \ln\left(\frac{\pi_i}{1 - \pi_i}\right) = \beta_0 + \boldsymbol{\beta}\mathbf{X}_i$$

where π_i is the probability that individual i is enrolled in university, $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ is the vector of log-odds of i being enrolled in university for a unit change in continuous variables and a discrete change in categorical variables, and $\mathbf{X}_i$ is a vector of covariates.

AMEs are reported to facilitate the interpretation of coefficients. AMEs of continuous variable k is calculated as the average of the partial derivative

$$AME_k = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \frac{\partial \hat{\pi}_i}{\partial x_{ki}}$$

while categorical variables are computed as the difference in predicted probability ($\hat{\pi}_i$) between category k and the reference (R) category for any number of k , such that

$$AME_{k \text{ vs } R} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n [\hat{\pi}_i(x_{ki} = k, \mathbf{X}_{-ki}) - \hat{\pi}_i(x_{ki} = R, \mathbf{X}_{-ki})]$$

Given the two-standard-deviation transformation, continuous variables are treated as binary variables and take the finite-difference form

$$AME_k^{2SD} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n [\hat{\pi}_i(x_{ki} = x_k^{+SD}, \mathbf{X}_{-ki}) - \hat{\pi}_i(x_{ki} = x_k^{-SD}, \mathbf{X}_{-ki})]$$

and represent the average change in $\hat{\pi}_i$ moving from 1SD below to 1SD above the mean – perhaps more accurately described as average contrast effects.

Appendix 4. Link to R script

https://github.com/Jhesspiece/MY497_Dissertation/blob/4cd7069ac1250b6a47529214759c7c5e18fd5414/analysis_main.R

I. Background

1. Where and when were you born?
 - a. Where did you grow up? What memories do you have of that area?
 - b. Have you ever moved? Did anything change when your area of residence changed?
2. Can you tell me a bit about your family?
 - a. Where are your parents from?
 - b. What languages are spoken at home?
 - c. What work did your parents do when you were young? What are they doing now?
 - d. Did you spend a lot of time with your parents growing up?
3. How is your relationship with your parents?
 - a. How does that relationship compare between when you were younger and now?
4. Do you have any siblings?
 - a. How is your relationship with them?
 - b. What are they doing now?

II. School experience

5. How was your school life in Korea overall?
 - a. Was there anything you particularly liked or found difficult about school?
6. Were your parents supportive of your school life and studies?
 - a. What kind of support was it?
 - b. Was there a difference between your father and mother?
7. Can you tell me about the friends you were close to?
 - a. Where are those friends now? Do you keep in touch?
8. How was your relationship with your teachers? Is there anyone who left a particular impression on you?
9. Did you attend any afterschool activities or private education?

III. High school and beyond

10. Did you have specific career goals when you were in school?
 - a. Did your thinking change as you got older?
 - b. Were there specific universities [companies] or majors [fields] you wanted to go to?
11. How was the university application [job preparation] process?
 - a. Was there anyone who was particularly helpful? [how did your teachers and the people around you (family, friends, etc.) react?]
 - b. Did financial considerations (tuition, cost of living away from home, etc.) influence your decisions about your path? [ask indirectly]
12. Why did you choose the university you currently attend [the company you work at]?
 - a. How do you find university [work] life?
 - b. How are you financing your tuition and living expenses?
13. What is your next step going forward?
 - a. How far do you want to go in your education or current career?
 - b. What expectations and apprehensions do you have for the future?